MVA VS BJP

THE WAR GETS NASTY

By Kiran D. Tare

On March 13, Mumbai Police officers reached the Malabar Hill home of leader of the opposition Devendra Fadnavis to question him on the data leak case that had rocked Maharashtra in 2021. The case pertains to confidential data on the postings of senior police officers, allegedly obtained by the state intelligence department by tapping the phone calls of politicians and power brokers. This is the first inquiry the ruling Maharashtra Vikas Aghadi (MVA) alliance government government has initiated against the BJP leader and former chief minister, and is reportedly retaliation against central agencies like the Enforcement Directorate (ED) conducting raids on ministers of the ruling alliance.

The police reaching Fadnavis's doorstep was a reaction to a CBI (Central Bureau of Investigation) inquiry conducted on Sanjay Pandey, the new Mumbai police commissioner, who just took charge of the coveted post on February 28. In a six-hour interrogation, the CBI sleuths reportedly wanted to know why Pandey asked his predecessor Param Bir Singh to withdraw a letter written to chief minister Uddhav Thackeray in March 2020 complaining that then home minister Anil Deshmukh had asked his men to collect Rs 100 crore from the bars and restaurants in Mumbai.

Embroiling Fadnavis and Pandey in investigations is the next level of the ongoing tussle between the state government and the Centre. With central agencies like the Enforcement Directorate (ED) conducting raids on 10 MVA leaders, the state has decided that retaliation is warranted. Fadnavis now alleges that the government is treating him like an accused whereas he is a whistle-blower in the case. "I didn't leak any confidential data. Whatever evidence I had I have submitted to the Union home ministry as they are the patrons of the IPS officers," he says.

The case pertains to two FIRs (first information reports) filed in Pune and Mumbai on March 2 against Rashmi Shukla, currently a joint commandant with the CRPF (Central Reserve Police Force). She is accused of illegally tapping the phone calls of several politicians, including state Congress president Nana Patole, when she was heading the state intelligence department in 2019. Interestingly, it was Fadnavis who first talked about the tapped phone conversations in March 2021. He submitted some 6 GB data in a hard disk to the Union home ministry, alleging that the MVA's leaders were involved in a police postings racket. This was based on a report Shukla had submitted to the state home department in July 2020. Fadnavis says he did not give details of the tapped phone conversations to the media. "If you remember, it was Nawab Malik who leaked the conversation to the media," he claims.

THE MVA ALLIANCE IN MAHARASHTRA IS FURIOUS. THEY BELIEVE THE BJP IS USING THE CENTRAL AGENCIES UNFAIRLY TO TARGET THEIR SENIOR LEADERS



ANI

GLOVES ARE OFF NCP's Nawab Malik at the ED office after his arrest, Feb. 23

Nawab Malik, the minister for minority welfare, is in judicial custody at present in a money laundering case. On February 23, the ED arrested Malik, the main accused in a 2005 land deal where he allegedly bought a three-acre plot in Mumbai's Kurla for Rs 75 lakh (market price: Rs 300 crore) from two aides of Haseena Parkar, the late sister of fugitive gangster Dawood Ibrahim. Malik's company, Solaris Investment Private Ltd, allegedly bought the land from Salim Patel, Parkar's bodyguard and driver, and Sardar Shahvali Khan, a convict in the 1993 Mumbai serial bomb blasts case.

The ED's remand application stated that Malik paid Rs 55 lakh in cash to